

Welcome Guide to Living in Brazil for International Students



UFRPE

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Welcome to your new home!

Welcome to Brazil and to the Federal Rural University of Pernambuco (UFRPE), kindly known as Ruralinda! We are excited you have chosen our institution for your academic journey. This guide was created to support you during your first months staying in Brazil.

Brazil is a vast, diverse and vibrant country, but, as any other place in the world, it has its own laws and traditions that may vary from your home country. Our goal here is to assure that your stay is safe, productive and filled with meaningful cultural exchanges!

For that, we have prepared this guide to assist you in integrating and adapting to life in Brazil.



GENERAL PRINCIPLES TO LIVING IN BRAZIL

Brazil is one of the most diverse countries in the world. Our strength is in our mix of various races, religions, cultures and identities.That is why it is important for you to respect all of them.

1) Respect above all: The basis of our coexistence is empathy. Regardless of origin, belief or orientation, everyone here has the right to feel safe and respected.

Brazil is a multicultural country formed by people from different ethnic, religious, social and cultural origins. Therefore, it is essential:

- to respect cultural, religious and linguistic differences;
- to avoid discriminatory or offensive comments;
- to value dialogue and peaceful coexistence;
- to treat every person with kindness and respect.

Discriminatory behaviors related to race, gender, sexual orientation, nationality, religion or social status are forbidden under Brazilian legislation.

Discrimination is a crime!

In Brazil, racism and any other form of discrimination or prejudice based on nationality, skin color, sexual orientation, ethnicity or religion are not

only frowned upon, but forbidden by law and can lead to academic and legal consequences. Thus, they are completely unacceptable.

Tip: offensive jokes about skin color, accents or religion are not accepted in our country. Refrain from this kind of behavior!

2) Kindness: you will see that Brazilians place great value in hearing “bom dia”, “por favor” and “obrigado”. These small expressions will go a long way in improving your interactions in Brazil, so don't hesitate to use them whenever you can!

- Greet people when entering and leaving places;
- Use expressions as “por favor” “obrigado(a)” and “com licença”;
- Show kindness in your daily interactions;
- Respect lines and shared spaces.

3) Harassment and Consent

In Brazil, social interactions tend to be friendlier, which may vary from region and context. It's important to know the difference between a gesture of kindness, empathy and cordiality, from those that actually represent intimacy, interest or an invite for something more. Avoid comments, gestures or approaches that may be interpreted as invasive, inappropriate or disrespectful. Respecting the body and personal space of others is essential.

Consent: “No” means no. This is true for physical and verbal exchanges. Respect others!

It's important to state that sexual or moral harassment may lead to expulsion from the university and criminal charges. Physical touch, although common in Brazil, must always respect the other person's boundaries and consent.

4) Use of alcohol and other substances

Alcohol: purchasing and consuming alcoholic beverages is allowed only for people that are at least 18 years old. It is forbidden to drive after consuming any amount of alcohol.
Drugs: possession and trafficking of illegal drugs are criminal offenses in Brazil. Violations may result in academic, administrative and legal consequences under Brazilian law.

5) Communication and Brazilian Culture

How to understand Brazilian culture on a daily basis?

Brazil has a vast regional diversity. Habits may vary between states and cities. Therefore, we recommend:

- to keep an open mind for new experiences;
- to respect local traditions;
- to participate in cultural and academic activities.

Brazil is known for its relaxed informal culture, but those that just arrived here may be unaware of some of its nuances:

- Kindness and Physical Touch: it is common for Brazilians to greet each with handshakes, hugs or

kisses on the cheek (usually one or two, depending on the region of the country). However, respecting the personal space of others is essential. If you are not comfortable, a smile and a wave are always a good alternative.

- The “Brazilian way”: this term is usually used to describe creative manners of handling daily situations. In the social context, it can be seen as flexibility. However, beware: In the institutional and legal contexts (for instance, an evaluation, meeting deadlines, issuing documents), the “Brazilian way” doesn't apply. UFRPE norms must be rigorously followed.

Invitations and Pontuality

In the academic context, always be on time. Being late in classes and exams may not be tolerated.
In the social context, if a Brazilian says to you “It's a date!”,it is not always a scheduled commitment, but, moreover than not, a sign of intention. In parties, to arrive a little late is usually the social standard.

In case there are doubts, conflicts or difficulties:

- seek to dialogue in a respectful manner;
- seek the assistance of the accountable sectors of the institution;
- avoid aggressive or disrespectful confrontations;
- use the official channels for complaints or requests.

Brazilian official language is Portuguese. Although some people may speak English or Spanish, learning basic expressions in Portuguese will facilitate your integration and adaptation in Brazil.

6) Shared Living and Common Spaces

In student residences, apartments, or other shared accommodations:

- respect quiet hours;
- keep shared spaces clean and organized;
- take care of shared belongings;
- avoid excessive noise.

Help use resources responsibly:

- save water and energy;
- dispose of waste properly;
- take care of common areas.

7) Respect Brazilian Laws

All foreigners must comply with Brazilian laws, including:

- immigration regulations;
- traffic laws;
- social conduct rules;
- laws related to public safety and order.

Ignorance of the law does not exempt anyone from responsibility.

8) Personal Safety

It's recommended that you:

- avoid displaying valuable belongings in public places;
- stay aware of your surroundings in crowded areas;
- use official transportation services and trusted apps;
- keep important documents in a safe place.

In case of an emergency, call

- **Police: 190**
- **Ambulance (SAMU): 192**
- **Fire department: 193**

Note: All these services are provided by the government, and free of charge in Brazil.

CONDUCT IN THE ACADEMIC COMMUNITY

At universities and other educational institutions, students are expected to:

- be punctual for classes, meetings, and academic activities;
- participate in academic activities ethically;
- be intellectually honest, avoiding plagiarism and academic frauds;
- use institutional spaces properly;
- respect professors, colleagues and staff members;

Interactions with professors: In Brazil, relationships

between students and professors tend to be less formal than in some other countries. However, this does not mean that respect is not expected. Always treat professors with due respect.

Interactions with administrative and support staff: It is essential to treat administrative, technical, and outsourced staff with respect, recognizing them as professionals who contribute directly to the university's daily operations and to the students' academic experience.

Rights and support to international students

International students and visitors have the right to:

- dignified and respectful treatment;
- access to university services;
- academic and administrative support;
- participation in cultural and scientific activities;
- a safe environment free from discrimination.

Intercultural interaction is an opportunity for personal and academic growth, but adapting to a new country can take time. Here are some suggestions to help you with that:

- participate in university events;
- build friendships across cultures;
- learn about Brazilian culture;
- seek psychological or institutional support when needed.

UFRPE reaffirms its commitment to welcoming, inclusion, and the well-being of international students. Everyone has the right to a safe, respectful academic environment free from discrimination, xenophobia, and all forms of violence. The university also seeks to provide academic support, institutional guidance, and referrals to psychological support, accessibility, and immigration or documentation services whenever needed. In cases of conflict, harassment, discrimination, or difficulties adapting to life in Brazil, students can contact the appropriate university offices and support channels for guidance, assistance, and follow-up.

Sensitive Situations and Conflicts

Practical Tips for Maintaining a good environment

Even with the best intentions, conflicts can arise. Here are some tips on how to handle them:

- Stay calm: A raised voice in Brazil does not always indicate aggression; sometimes it is simply a sign of enthusiasm. Try to resolve misunderstandings through calm and direct conversation.
- Avoid offensive arguments: Discussions about politics, religion, or soccer can become heated. If you feel that a conversation is becoming offensive or disrespectful, it is perfectly acceptable to step away from the discussion.

- Seek mediation: If you feel that you have been treated unfairly or are facing a conflict that you cannot resolve on your own (whether with a classmate, professor, or other university professional) contact the Office of International Affairs or your program coordinator. Do not try to handle serious situations on your own.

Consequences of Inappropriate Behavior

It is important to understand that failure to comply with the rules has real consequences.

- Academic Field: actions such as plagiarism, harassment, or vandalism may result in warnings, suspension, or even permanent expulsion from the university, which may invalidate your student visa.
- Legal Field: crimes established under the Brazilian Penal Code (such as robbery, assault, racism, and drug trafficking) may result in fines, imprisonment, and, ultimately, deportation proceedings.
- Student Visa: Your legal stay in the country is subject to your academic performance and conduct at the university. Always keep your documents up to date.

Where to seek assistance

You are not alone!

Whenever you need guidance or support, you can contact the following offices:

- Office of International Affairs, by email (international@ufrpe.br) or in person at the IPÊ Institute.
- Internationalization Coordination, by email (cippg.prpg@ufrpe.br) or in person at the Office of the Dean of Graduate Studies.

If you have questions about academic or immigration regulations, or about aspects of everyday life in Brazil, contact UFRPE's internationalization offices before making any decisions.

We hope this guide will help you on your new journey. Culture shock is normal, but integration is a rewarding process. Explore, ask questions, participate in events, and allow yourself to experience the best that Brazil and our university have to offer. We are here to support you every step of the way. Have a great semester, and know that you can always count on us for support!

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Provost of Graduate Studies (PRPG)



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